

Steam deals

Steam, the popular game delivery service offered discounts up to 75 per cent on games leading up to the new year

Goodbye VGA

Large PC manufacturers have decided to completely phase out the old VGA connector used to connect PCs to displays

to be increased as the size of screen increases. And moreover, Android is not really made for resistive touch displays. One good example to prove our point are the menus. We had a really tough time scrolling on these tablets and often started an application or shifted an icon to a new place instead. Add to this the fact that regular use of resistive touch will surely scratch the screen, and you have a rather ugly situation. Also, the Android Phi is based on the ancient Android 1.5.

THE BAD

Another major concern with these tablets is that although the manufacturers boast of '70,000 Android market apps', it is questionable how many of them would actually run on these devices. Eliminate those that use multitouch. We could barely get 'Angry Birds' (our favorite game for Android) to run on the StylePad, with lag and texture problems. Further, the Phi has very limited apps as it's running an obsolete OS.

THE GOOD

We forget that these tablets are priced at half the price of Samsung Galaxy Tab. Yet, they have talents of their own.

Android Phi has an internal memory of 8 GB and a USB-on-the-go that Nokia's current flagship phone N8 boasts of. You can plug in your pen drive into this port using an adapter, and access it on the tablet.

The Style-Pad is a port heaven: A USB port that can be used to directly connect a pen-drive or a 3G dongle! Sealing the deal is mini-HDMI to take full advantage of the abundant video talent of this device. The device plays everything. MP3s, AVIs, MKVs, FLACs. You name it, and this device shall play without a stutter, without an effort. Adding further gloss are two powerful stereo speakers at the back. It wouldn't be a bad deal to buy this device solely as a 7-inch PMP. The StylePad is very good value for money.

WINDOWS PHI

Many of the problems that plague the Android Phi are also present in the very similar Windows Phi, running Windows CE 6.0: The screen and touch are bad. So

are battery life and build. But there are some things that work for this version of Phi.

The glossy back on Android version has been replaced with a rougher brushed metal finish, making handling easier. Although the touchscreen is bad, it works here because Windows CE is much more suited for resistive touch than Android. Video playback (up to 1080p) is nearly flawless. But what impressed us most about the Phi was the Office suite bundled with the device, which provides nearly all features that an office suite on PC does. We found it more feature-laden than any other office suite we tried on the other tablets (bundled or paid!). So, if you can master typing with a stylus, you have a perfect office companion in this device.

Windows CE is generally poor and unstable on the device. It had more than its fair share of lags and hang-ups.

All in all, we would rate the tablet almost on par with SMC StylePad. The video playback is similar, and the lack of a proper application market in Windows CE is covered by an excellent office suite. We highly recommend this tablet if you think you need an office on the go.

LEAF 10-INCH TABLOID

Leaf 10 inch Tabloid is the largest tablet we have in our 'economy class' of tablets. The tablet is very similar to SMC StylePad, with the same hardware inside. But although the StylePad performed reasonably, using the Leaf Tabloid is a pain. This is expected when a similar hardware powers a much larger screen and renders many more pixels.

The build quality is better than all other tablets in the same price category. The screen of the tablet looks decent, but has poor viewing angles.

We think the touch-screen of this device should actually be called a press-screen. Perfect for ladies with long nails, because nails are the only way to get it to work.



Like the StylePad, this 10-inch tablet is exceptional at playing videos and music. Any format at 1080p! And on this huge screen, it beats any of our tablets for its video playback abilities.

Although the device runs Android 2.1, you would never be able to take full advantage of the operating system due to the poor hardware and very poor application compatibility. The device is like a big PMP that runs a few apps.

The so-called 3G version of the Tabloid has a WCDMA based external dongle to be attached to the USB OTG port.

OUR VERDICT

With an overall score of 71.39, Samsung Galaxy Tab is the pick of the tablets, outracing the older iPad with its powerful hardware and a nearly-flawless FroYo. If you have a tighter budget, the SMC StylePad is probably halfway between the wheat and the chaff with a score of 45.09. As the scores suggest, the tablets have still got a little way to go before they even come close being a replacement for laptops.

Out of the 9 tablets we tested, we came to a single conclusion: The good tablets are very expensive, and the cheaper ones are nowhere close to being a replacement for your laptop. So if you have iPad-dreams, you might have to wait till you can buy a decent tablet without breaking your bank. Watch out for the launch of the impressive BlackBerry Playbook and the very-promising Adam from the Indian company Notion Ink (which is taking pre-orders as we write). Be patient, and these newer ones might be worth the wait. Lie back and relax, we'll be here to tell their tale. **d**